

Silver, Sweat, and the Crown: Coinage Debasement in Late-Medieval England,

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Review of Numismatic History, Vol. 14, No. 3 (1987) - JID-002

Abstract

Between the reigns of Edward III and Henry IV the silver content of the English penny declined in a series of poorly documented adjustments. Drawing on mint indentures, hoard analysis, and the neglected records of the Tower assay, this paper reconstructs the sequence of debasements and distinguishes deliberate fiscal manipulation by the Crown from the slow erosion of weight caused by clipping and ordinary wear. I argue that contemporaries understood the difference perfectly well, and that the language of 'sweating' coin in court records is evidence of a sophisticated popular theory of money.

Introduction

The medieval penny was a remarkably stable object for most of its life, and that stability is precisely why its periods of instability repay study. A coin that is expected to hold its weight becomes, when it does not, a sensitive instrument for reading the fiscal pressures on the state that issues it.

This paper covers the seventy-odd years from the great recoinage of Edward III to the end of Henry IV's reign, a window in which the standard penny lost an appreciable fraction of its silver. The challenge is to separate official debasement, decided in council and executed at the mint, from the diffuse private debasement worked by clippers and sweaters on coins already in circulation.

Sources and the Problem of the Indenture

Mint indentures, the contracts between the Crown and the master of the mint, nominally fix the weight and fineness of new coin. They are the obvious starting point, but they record intention rather than outcome. An indenture that specifies a lighter penny tells us the Crown chose to debase; it does not tell us how much lighter the coins in a labourer's purse actually were a decade later.

For that we must turn to hoards. The buried savings of the anxious are the social historian's good fortune, and three hoards from the period, weighed coin by coin, allow a direct comparison between the legal standard and the circulating reality. The gap between them is the measure of private erosion.

Clipping versus Sweating

Two illicit techniques degraded coin in opposite styles. Clipping shaved metal from the rim and left a visibly smaller coin; it was crude, profitable, and easy to detect once milled edges were a distant invention. Sweating was subtler: coins were sealed in a bag and shaken until a fine dust of silver abraded from their surfaces, leaving each individual piece almost unchanged while the bag's owner accumulated a small fortune in metal.

Court records distinguish the two offences with a precision that surprised earlier historians. The vocabulary of 'sweating' appears in indictments well before any royal

proclamation defined it, which suggests that the practice and the popular understanding of it ran ahead of the law. Ordinary people, in other words, held a working theory that the value of a coin lived in its metal, not in the king's stamp.

Fiscal Logic of the Crown

Why would a king debase his own coin? The short answer is war finance. Each reduction in the silver content allowed the mint to strike more pennies from the same quantity of bullion, and the difference accrued to the Crown as seigniorage. In a century of French campaigns this was a standing temptation.

Yet the debasements studied here were modest and intermittent, not the runaway inflations seen on the Continent. I argue this restraint reflects a real fear of the popular monetary theory described above: a Crown that pushed too hard risked coin being refused or melted, and refusal of the king's money was a short step from refusal of the king.

Conclusion

The slow lightening of the English penny in this period was the product of two distinct hands, the Crown's and the clipper's, working at different speeds and for different ends. Reading them apart requires holding indenture, hoard, and indictment in the same frame. The result is a portrait of a medieval public that thought about money in surprisingly modern terms.

References

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